



GRIMES COUNTY BUDGET HEARINGS

OFFICIAL MINUTES — WEDNESDAY, JULY 29, 2026

The Grimes County Budget Hearings met on Wednesday, July 29, 2026, at 9:00 A.M. Members Present: County Judge Joe Fauth, Commissioner Chad Mallett, Commissioner David Tullos, Commissioner Michael Raska, Commissioner Phillip Cox.

County Judge Joe Fauth called the meeting to order.

Discuss and review the Grimes County FY 2027 departmental budget requests. — Joe Fauth III

County Judge Joe Fauth opened the morning's budget review sessions by welcoming attendees and establishing the schedule for the day, which included presentations from the tax appraisal office, juvenile probation, nonprofits, and maintenance departments. The Chief Appraiser Mark Boehnke presented the tax appraisal budget of \$793,231, noting that the appraised value of Grimes County had increased from approximately \$5.5 billion to \$5.7 billion. Boehnke explained that the final budget amount could fluctuate based on the tax rates set by schools, the county, and cities, as the appraisal district's bill is calculated as a percentage of the total tax levy. He reported that collections for 2025 taxes were tracking well and discussed the ongoing annual aerial flyover program, which he credited as a significant cost-saving measure that had evolved from once every three years to annually under the court's approval. Boehnke noted the potential impact of recent legislative changes, including increased homestead exemptions for seniors and expanded property tax caps, which had removed substantial value from the tax roll. Commissioner Phillip Cox inquired about whether the flyover used an airplane or drone and received clarification that it was an actual aircraft that conducted the survey in late December through early January, with processed results delivered around March on data disks that were loaded onto county servers. The discussion turned to the appraised value increases and potential new development, particularly regarding SpaceX and TerraFab projects, though Boehnke expressed cautious skepticism, stating he would not believe in major development until he saw physical evidence of construction activity. Following the tax appraisal office discussion, the court briefly addressed the animal rescue facility after representatives Michele Gremillion and others presented the Grimes County Animal Rescue budget. The court took a tour of the facility to visually assess its condition. Upon returning, Commissioner David Tullos delivered an extensive commentary noting the facility's deteriorating walls, persistent odor issues, and the significant increase in law enforcement animal engagements from one in 2024 to 201 in 2025, which had generated approximately \$66,000 in expenses. Gremillion explained that the rescue had requested \$50,000 in funding but was initially budgeted at \$12,000 in the preliminary document. Judge Fauth proposed allocating \$20,000 to the animal rescue for operational costs and tasked Facilities Director Rodney Floyd with determining what additional funds might be needed from the facilities budget for building maintenance, as the structure, though operated by the private nonprofit, was county-owned property under a ten-year lease agreement. County Auditor Jessi Murphy and others reviewed numerous budget line items across multiple departments and funds throughout the day, including discussions of IT requests for contract management and a Planet Bids system, professional services, equipment purchases, and capital improvement priorities. The court engaged in substantial discussion regarding the anticipated SpaceX

and TerraFab payments and how those future revenues might be allocated to major capital projects, including a potential jail renovation, Precinct 4 facilities, and courthouse improvements, with recognition that the county would likely need to explore certificates of obligation financing for projects estimated in the \$18 to \$20 million range.

Action: Motion by Commissioner Michael Raska to Adjourn the meeting. Seconded by Commissioner Phillip Cox. Carried.

ADJOURNMENT

A motion to adjourn the meeting was made, seconded, and carried. The meeting adjourned at 1:07 PM.

THE OFFICIAL MINUTES OF THE GRIMES COUNTY BUDGET HEARINGS ON July 29th, 2026, ARE HEREBY APPROVED.

Barbara Kimich County Clerk